

Cleaners could get onto the train and clean coaches and toilets. As one switched from steam to diesel/electric traction, these water stops became unnecessary. In the US, there is documentation of ghost towns, created because water stops became redundant. While growing up, those water stops were part of train travel, an opportunity to explore new stations. Once air-conditioning was introduced in trains, you could no longer raise or lower the windows. Somehow, you no longer felt that you were travelling. The journey was more comfortable, but surely less fun. I remember travelling on the Howrah Rajdhani in 1971, soon after it was introduced. There was a library and the food was completely different from what used to be the norm on trains earlier. Back then, civil aviation wasn't that easily accessible and was relatively much more expensive. Trains were the most popular form of travelling long distances, but the Rajdhani and Shatabdi changed our perceptions of trains and train travel. A part of the romance vanished.

There was plenty of romance associated with trains. Trains were introduced in India soon after they were introduced in Britain and elsewhere (1853 is the official year of birth). Therefore, quite a bit of experimentation took place with, and in, Indian Railways. There were so many novel solutions, proposed and often not implemented. For example, Colonel Grant of the Bombay Engineers, who authored a monograph in 1850, thought that permanent railway tracks along the surface of the ground were not practical, because of high mountains, impassable rivers, thick forests and jungles, and herds of cattle and other animals. He proposed that railway tracks should be suspended through the entire length using suspension chains, at a minimum height that was eight feet above the ground, high enough to avoid animals and to allow for a fairly uniform alignment. Extraordinary though the idea was, models of this plan were prepared and exhibited. The Court of Directors of the East India Company posed some questions to the Governor General, Lord Dalhousie. What about periodic rains and inundations, continued action of violent winds, the influence of a vertical sun, the ravages of insects and vermin, the destructive growth of spontaneous vegetation of underwood upon earth and brickwork, the unenclosed and unprotected tracts of country through which the railroad would pass, and the difficulty and expense of securing the